

Perspectives, Methods and Skills for Science, Technology, Innovation Studies

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Week 9

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Discourse Analysis



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Outcomes for the Class

1. To understand and develop the skills to undertake discourse analysis
2. To understand the differences between content, thematic and discourse analysis
3. To develop tools and techniques for reading critically using concepts from discourse analysis

Content



1. Different types of analysis (review)
2. The basics of discourse analysis
3. Key theories and ideas for discourse analysis
4. Doing discourse analysis

Types of analysis (review)

Types of Analysis: Content Analysis

Content analysis examines what is in our data, e.g:

- How many times the word “sustainability” is used
- How many of the sample identifies as male/female/other

Content analysis often provides important descriptive information but usually needs to be supplemented with other types of analysis in qualitative projects.



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Thematic Analysis vs. Discourse Analysis

Thematic Analysis	Discourse Analysis
Studies what is said	Studies how things are said - you don't just ask if a theme is discussed, you ask <i>how</i> that theme is discussed (Salkind 2010)
Questions often start with “what”	Questions often start with “how”

Sample Research Questions?

- On the topic of sustainable holiday travel?
 - On the topic of cycle lanes in cities
- On the topic of locational electricity pricing?

Thematic Analysis vs. Discourse Analysis

Thematic
Analysis

Discourse
Analysis



- There is overlap – it's possible to ask the same research question using either approach
- You will cite different analytical methods, depending on which one you use
- They are underlain by different research philosophies

Basics of Discourse Analysis

Understanding Discourse Analysis (DA)

- DA is done and understood differently depending on the theories and field you start from
- In general, DA examines language as containing information on dynamics that exist beyond an individual person – things like culture, predominant beliefs, motivations, values. It involves "*the spirit of sceptical readings*" (Gill 2006)
- DA can be defined as 'the close study of language and language use as evidence of aspects of society and social life'. (Taylor, 2013:7) - but there are lots of different definitions and this can make things confusing

What is a “discourse”

This also depends on who is defining it. For example:

- Foucault: Discourses are broader than specific conversations. They exist as shared meanings in society and are expressed and reproduced through language
- Fairclough: ‘Language as a form of social practice’ (2001b, pp. 229–66)
- Gee: Discourses *are* social practice – and therefore include not just words, but also gestures, postures, ways of acting (1992, p. 107)

You can use any definition you like, as long as you clearly explain and justify why it is appropriate in your research context.

Key Theories and Ideas for Understanding Discourse



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Roots of Discourse Analysis

- There are two main traditions:
 - Study of linguistics and grammar (but studied as embedded in social context) – exploring features of language (the starting point is language and this is used to explore context)
 - Study of sociology and psychology to try to understand collective meaning by studying language (their starting point is collective dynamics and discourse is a way to understand how these are expressed)



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Foucault and language as the construction of knowledge

For Foucault:

- There is no universal truth but rather we construct what is "true" by the way we understand it and talk about it
- Our 'truths' may not be logically constructed but instead rest on accepted ideas
- This makes knowledge political as there is potential to shape what is considered "true" in different directions



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Language as communication

- Sociolinguists view language as carrying social meanings and values, and these can change and evolve over time
- You can learn about social situations by studying language (e.g. accents and how they are presented, phrases used in certain settings)



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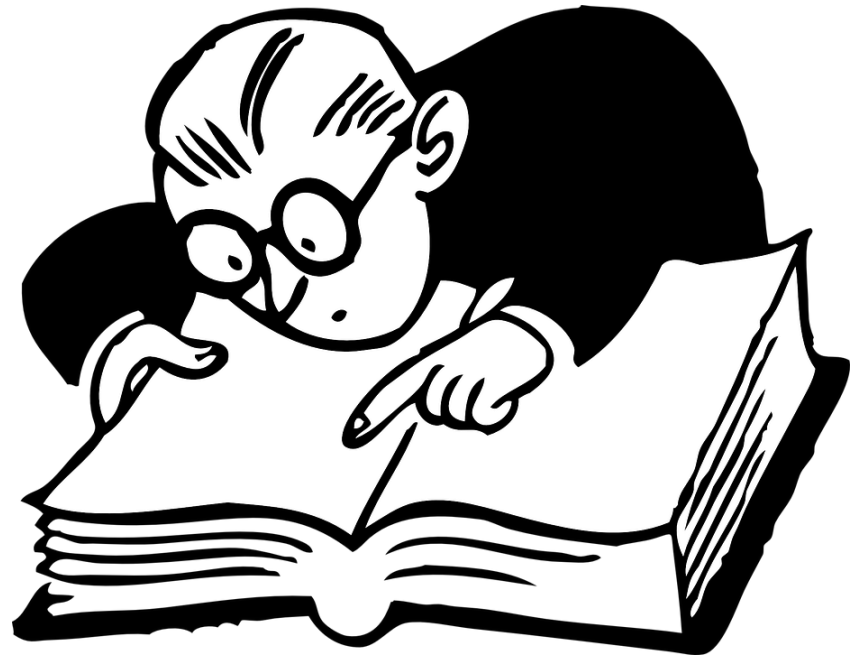
Language as social practice

- Social meaning is embedded in "orderly social activities" or social habits and practices
- "Conversation analysis" can be used to understand interactions between people
 - In contrast to meaning being socially constructed and shaping the conversation, meaning is constructed within the conversation



Navigating theories

- In practice, many ideas about discourse are often combined when we actually conduct a discourse analysis
- The general point is that the language and discourses that we use, and that we encounter, are not neutral – they can tell us things about how the wider world operates



Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA)

- CDA (Fairclough, van Dijk) is a prominent DA technique concerned with the ways elites use language to dominate others
- It examines both *how* something came to be viewed as “true”, and what that “truth” is
- It is often particularly interested in who can shape ideas, values and shared understanding through the media or other avenues



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- CDA is a theoretical framework that is usually used with text-based data sources.
- The theories that define CDA are explicitly about power
- Studying CDA means that you are “highlighting and describing power relations” and looking at how specific ideas and values are create and reinforced across society.



CDA and hegemony

Many questions that use CDA are interested in how discourse is used to make people think that specific realities are in their best interest.

‘If the minds of the dominated can be influenced in such a way that they accept dominance, and act in the interest of the powerful out of their own free will, we use the term *hegemony*’ (van Dijk, 1998, p. 372)



Current examples of instances where people act in the interests of the powerful?

Doing Discourse Analysis

Data for Discourse Analysis

- Data for DA can come from many different sources
 - Texts like media articles, reports, historical documents, even government policy documents
 - Video or audio recordings or live situations
 - Social media data
 - Interview or focus group transcripts
- Note that the form of data may also be important and provide detail on the context e.g.
 - It may be relevant that discourse is occurring through a hand written letter instead of an email
 - The same text will be interpreted differently if it is in a journal article or a newspaper opinion piece.

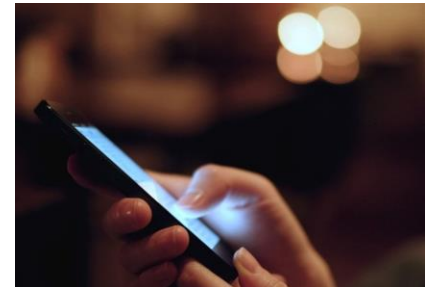
Asking Questions for Discourse Analysis

- The questions you ask matter.
- "When you do discourse analysis, you might focus on:
 - - The purposes and effects of different types of language
 - - Cultural rules and conventions in communication
 - - How values, beliefs and assumptions are communicated
 - - How language use relates to its social, political and historical context"(Luo 2020)



Conducting CDA

1. Begin to identify initial themes in your data
 - Read your documents and try to *inductively* find themes
2. Review your codes and try to go beneath the surface
 - Are there words or phrases that have specific meanings?
 - Are particular positions or behaviours being supported?
3. Using the patterns and dynamics you find, propose conclusions about how power is operating in this situation.



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Frameworks for DA

Discourse analysis makes use of theoretical frameworks that direct you to look at how language is used and meaning conveyed or constructed.

For CDA, these theories are based on power.

It is also often helpful to look for specific patterns that you might expect from the literature (e.g. ways that specific words or ideas are used, ways that certain media are used) – these more detailed themes can help you build a more specific analytical framework for examining your data.



Case Study:

- Read or skim the following article: ['It's hyped up': climate change skeptics in the path of Hurricane Florence](#)
- How is climate scepticism represented in this article in The Guardian newspaper?
- How is language used (e.g. tone, use of metaphors, specific words that are repeated)?
- How are images used?
- How is expertise framed?
- In your group, give your themes labels (note that this is coding)



<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2018/sep/19/hurricane-florence-climate-change-deniers-north-carolina>

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